

HR TRAINING

MODULE 1

HR Operations

STUDENT WORKBOOK

100 Practice Exercises — Written Response, Multiple Choice, and True/False

A Traction Outsourcing Limited HR Training Resource

BUILT BY AFRICANS, FOR AFRICA

Module 1: HR Operations — Workbook

A Traction Outsourcing Limited HR Training Resource

How to Use This Workbook

This workbook accompanies Module 1: HR Operations and contains 100 exercises organized into three parts. Work through each part in order, or use individual exercises to review a specific section of the module. Exercises are grouped by type, and within each type they follow the same section order as the module (1.1 through 1.8).

Type A — Written Response (20 exercises, A1–A20)

Each item presents a question, statement, or workplace scenario drawn from the module. Write your answer in the ruled space provided, or on a separate sheet if you need more room. These exercises have no single correct wording — they are graded by your facilitator against the concepts covered in the module.

Type B — Multiple Choice (40 exercises, B1–B40)

Each item presents a question or scenario with four possible answers (A–D). Mark the box beside the one best answer. Check your work against the Multiple Choice Answer Key at the back of this workbook.

Type C — True/False (40 exercises, C1–C40)

Each item presents a statement drawn from the module. Mark whether the statement is True or False. Check your work against the True/False Answer Key at the back of this workbook.

Exercise Breakdown by Module Section

Module Section	Type A	Type B	Type C	Total
1.1 HR Operations	4	7	7	18
1.2 Organizational Strategy	2	5	5	12
1.3 Effective HR Management	3	7	7	17
1.4 HR Technology and Communication	2	5	5	12
1.5 Organizational Design and Development	3	5	5	13
1.6 Organizational Culture	3	5	5	13
1.7 Ethics	1	3	3	7
1.8 HR Research and Analytics	2	3	3	8
Total	20	40	40	100

Part I — Written Response Exercises (A1–A20)

Read each scenario, statement, or question carefully and write your response in the space provided.

1.1 HR Operations

A1. Your organization has recently grown from 40 employees to 150 employees within two years and has never had a formal HR department. Using what you have learned about HR generalists, HR specialists, and support roles, describe how you would begin structuring an HR department for this company. What positions would you create first, and why?

Your response:

A2. Explain the three major purposes of HR policies. Then describe why organizations that have official written policies are expected to follow them even in situations where departing from the policy might seem more convenient.

Your response:

A3. Compare the advisory/counseling role, the service role, and the control role of an HR manager. Using an example from your own workplace or a company you know, describe a situation in which an HR manager might need to perform each of these three roles.

Your response:

A4. A small company with 55 employees is deciding whether it needs a formal HR manager position. Using the module's guidance on HR generalists and specialists, advise the company on when this transition typically becomes necessary and which responsibilities should shift from line managers to a dedicated HR function.

Your response:

1.2 Organizational Strategy

A5. Using the SWOT framework, outline a brief strategic analysis (one or two points under each of Strengths, Weaknesses, Opportunities, and Threats) for a business you are familiar with. Explain how HR could contribute to at least one part of that analysis.

Your response:

A6. Explain the difference between a vision statement and a mission statement. Then draft a one-paragraph mission statement for a real or fictional organization, incorporating a purpose statement, a business statement, and a values statement.

Your response:

1.3 Effective HR Management

A7. Explain the three major purposes of budgets (coordination and integration, motivation, and control and evaluation). Describe how a poorly managed HR training budget could fail to achieve each of these three purposes.

Your response:

A8. Choose any three HR metrics discussed in this module (for example, Cost per Hire, Turnover Rate, HR Expense Factor, or Time to Fill). For each one, write the formula, explain what it measures, and describe one HR decision that could be improved by tracking it over time.

Your response:

A9. A company is considering outsourcing all of its HR functions to a single vendor through an HR business process outsourcing (HR BPO) arrangement. Using the module's discussion of outsourcing,

write a short recommendation on which HR functions the company should keep in-house and which are good candidates for outsourcing, and explain your reasoning.

Your response:

1.4 HR Technology and Communication

A10. Describe what a gap analysis is and how an HR manager could use it to determine whether the organization's HRIS needs to be upgraded. Give an example of a "gap" that might exist between a company's current HRIS functionality and its ideal HRIS.

Your response:

A11. Your company is drafting a new technology-use policy covering employees' use of social media and company devices. Using the module's guidelines, write four policy statements you would include and explain why each is important for balancing the company's interests with employees' rights.

Your response:

1.5 Organizational Design and Development

A12. Compare functional departmentalization and product departmentalization. For a fast-growing consumer-goods company launching multiple new product lines, which structure would you recommend, and why?

Your response:

A13. Explain the concept of span of control and describe the four situational variables that influence whether a wide or narrow span of control is appropriate. Apply this to a call-center environment versus a research-and-development team.

Your response:

A14. A manager complains that employees in the company's matrix structure feel confused about who their "real" boss is. Using the module's discussion of matrix structures, explain why this happens and what the manager could do to reduce the resulting role ambiguity.

Your response:

1.6 Organizational Culture

A15. Explain the difference between organizational climate and organizational culture, using the weather-versus-seasons analogy from the module. Describe one climate-level change and one culture-level change that might occur in a company after a merger.

Your response:

A16. Using the four levels of organizational culture (artifacts, norms, values, and underlying assumptions), analyze a workplace or organization you are familiar with. Give one concrete example of each level as it appears in that organization.

Your response:

A17. A company wants to change its culture from one of high control and distrust of employees to one of trust and employee empowerment. Using the steps for changing organizational culture described in the module, outline a brief action plan for this company.

Your response:

1.7 Ethics

A18. Explain the difference between deontological and teleological definitions of morality. Describe a real or hypothetical HR decision (such as a termination or a pay decision) and analyze whether it would be considered moral under each definition.

Your response:

1.8 HR Research and Analytics

A19. Compare archive data, observations, interviews, and questionnaires as HR data-gathering methods. For each, list one advantage and one disadvantage described in the module, and recommend which method(s) you would use to investigate rising absenteeism in a department.

Your response:

A20. Choose two of the charts or graphs described in the module (for example, histogram, pie chart, line graph, scatter plot, or Gantt chart) and explain, in your own words, what kind of HR data each is best suited to display. Then describe an HR question at your own organization that each chart could help answer.

Your response:

Part II — Multiple Choice Exercises (B1–B40)

Mark the box beside the one best answer for each item.

1.1 HR Operations

B1. Which of the following is NOT one of the major HR functions described in the module?

- ☐ **A)** Staffing
- ☐ **B)** Performance management
- ☐ **C)** Marketing research
- ☐ **D)** Safety, health, and security

B2. In most organizations, who has primary responsibility for evaluating an employee's day-to-day job performance?

- ☐ **A)** The HR department alone
- ☐ **B)** Department managers and supervisors
- ☐ **C)** The chief financial officer
- ☐ **D)** External auditors

B3. Which document is described as a compilation of all the policy decisions a company has made, and tends to be more formal, lengthy, and difficult to read than an employee handbook?

- ☐ **A)** The employee handbook
- ☐ **B)** The policy manual
- ☐ **C)** The mission statement
- ☐ **D)** The business plan

B4. According to the module, at approximately what employee count does an organization typically need a separate staff position to coordinate human resource functions?

- ☐ **A)** 10 to 20 employees
- ☐ **B)** 100 to 200 employees
- ☐ **C)** 500 to 1,000 employees
- ☐ **D)** Only once it is unionized

B5. The human resource business partner (HRBP) is best described as:

- ☐ **A)** An administrative role within the HR department
- ☐ **B)** A consultant to the executive team who collaborates with HR but is not generally part of the HR department
- ☐ **C)** A support-level clerical position
- ☐ **D)** The person solely responsible for payroll

B6. Which of the following best defines a budget, as distinct from a financial statement?

- ☐ **A)** A record of a company's actual past performance
- ☐ **B)** An itemized estimate of expected operating results for a future period
- ☐ **C)** A summary of shareholder equity only
- ☐ **D)** A legal filing required only of public companies

B7. In zero-based budgeting, budgets are:

- ☐ **A)** Based on the prior year's budget with an added percentage
- ☐ **B)** Set entirely by upper-level management with no input from departments
- ☐ **C)** Started from zero, requiring managers to justify every expense
- ☐ **D)** Calculated using a fixed enrollment-based formula

1.2 Organizational Strategy

B8. According to the module, competitive advantage is best described as:

- ☐ **A)** Having the fewest employees in an industry
- ☐ **B)** Providing a product or service in a competitive market better than your competitors
- ☐ **C)** Merging with as many competitors as possible
- ☐ **D)** Avoiding all forms of environmental scanning

B9. In the SWOT method, "opportunities" and "threats" are analyzed as part of:

- ☐ **A)** The organization's internal resources
- ☐ **B)** The external environment
- ☐ **C)** The employee handbook
- ☐ **D)** The compensation structure

B10. Which step comes first in the strategic management process described in the module?

- ☐ **A)** Implement the strategy
- ☐ **B)** Evaluate and monitor results
- ☐ **C)** Identify the organization's mission
- ☐ **D)** Formulate functional strategies

B11. The case of U.S. Steel in the module is used to illustrate:

- ☐ **A)** A successful proactive SWOT strategy
- ☐ **B)** A company's failure to adapt its strategy to competitive forces over time
- ☐ **C)** The benefits of a matrix structure
- ☐ **D)** The advantages of employee leasing

B12. Which of the following is NOT typically listed as a common component of a business plan?

- ☐ **A)** An executive summary
- ☐ **B)** A market analysis and marketing plan
- ☐ **C)** A description of the management team
- ☐ **D)** A detailed employee disciplinary log

1.3 Effective HR Management

B13. Which of the following is one of the three major purposes of budgets described in the module?

- ☐ **A)** Motivation
- ☐ **B)** Advertising
- ☐ **C)** Unionization
- ☐ **D)** Departmentalization

B14. The metric “Revenue ÷ Total Number of FTE” is known as:

- ☐ **A)** Human Capital ROI
- ☐ **B)** Revenue Factor (Revenue per FTE)
- ☐ **C)** Cost per Hire
- ☐ **D)** HR Expense Factor

B15. Turnover Rate is calculated as:

- ☐ **A)** Total Training Costs ÷ Headcount
- ☐ **B)** Number of separations during the month ÷ Average number of employees during the month, × 100
- ☐ **C)** Total Cost of Health Care ÷ Total Employees
- ☐ **D)** HR Expenses ÷ Total Employees

B16. According to a national benchmarking study cited in the module, the average time-to-fill a position is approximately:

- ☐ **A)** 10 days
- ☐ **B)** 36 days
- ☐ **C)** 90 days
- ☐ **D)** 6 months

B17. Recruitment process outsourcing is abbreviated in the module as:

- ☐ **A)** RPO
- ☐ **B)** LSO
- ☐ **C)** PEO
- ☐ **D)** HRIS

B18. A professional employer organization (PEO) typically:

- ☐ **A)** Has no legal responsibility for the workers it manages
- ☐ **B)** Co-employs workers under a contractual relationship that shares management responsibilities
- ☐ **C)** Only provides training and development services
- ☐ **D)** Cannot pay wages or employment taxes on behalf of employees

B19. Which of the following is described in the module as a disadvantage of using “Revenue per FTE” as the primary HR effectiveness metric?

- ☐ **A)** It motivates managers to reduce costs rather than headcount
- ☐ **B)** It cannot be benchmarked against other companies
- ☐ **C)** It can motivate managers to use expensive overtime rather than hire additional FTEs
- ☐ **D)** It only applies to nonprofit organizations

1.4 HR Technology and Communication

B20. A human resource information system (HRIS) is best described as:

- ☐ **A)** A single spreadsheet used only by payroll
- ☐ **B)** A collection of information about the people working for the organization
- ☐ **C)** A type of employee handbook

- ☐ **D)** A synonym for a labor union

B21. Software-as-a-service (SaaS) HR platforms are also commonly referred to as:

- ☐ **A)** Cloud computing arrangements
☐ **B)** Employee leasing
☐ **C)** Matrix structures
☐ **D)** Functional departmentalization

B22. Which of the following is listed as a technology that allows virtual teams to share information?

- ☐ **A)** A wiki on the company intranet
☐ **B)** A paper-based policy manual only
☐ **C)** An in-person-only meeting requirement
☐ **D)** A single fixed office location

B23. According to the module, employers generally CANNOT prohibit employees from:

- ☐ **A)** Posting client lists or trade secrets online
☐ **B)** Discussing wages or working conditions with coworkers, since this may be protected activity
☐ **C)** Using company devices for any personal reason whatsoever without restriction
☐ **D)** Harassing coworkers online

B24. What is the recommended practice for making employee communications more likely to be read, according to the module?

- ☐ **A)** Use long, formal legal language
☐ **B)** Keep sentences short (normally under 20 words) and discussions to less than a page
☐ **C)** Avoid any use of graphics
☐ **D)** Send the same message through as many channels as possible without editing the list

1.5 Organizational Design and Development

B25. Which type of departmentalization groups all jobs related to a similar function, such as accounting, into the same department?

- ☐ **A)** Product departmentalization
☐ **B)** Functional departmentalization
☐ **C)** Matrix departmentalization
☐ **D)** Geographic departmentalization

B26. A major disadvantage of functional departmentalization noted in the module is that it:

- ☐ **A)** Increases duplication of staff functions
☐ **B)** Reduces communication and cooperation between departments
☐ **C)** Cannot be used in large organizations
☐ **D)** Eliminates the need for specialization

B27. "Standardization of skills" as a coordinating mechanism is best illustrated by:

- ☐ **A)** A supervisor directly telling subordinates what to do
☐ **B)** An assembly-line job governed by standard operating procedures
☐ **C)** A surgical team coordinating based on their shared technical training

- ☐ **D)** Informal meetings and task forces

B28. According to the module, a range of how many subordinates per supervisor is often recommended, although a much larger span may be appropriate in some situations?

- ☐ **A)** One to two
☐ **B)** Four to six
☐ **C)** Twenty to thirty
☐ **D)** Sixty to seventy-five

B29. In a matrix organizational structure, employees typically:

- ☐ **A)** Report only to a single functional manager
☐ **B)** Report to both a product manager and a functional manager with equal authority
☐ **C)** Have no direct supervisor at all
☐ **D)** Are organized exclusively by geographic region

1.6 Organizational Culture

B30. Which of the following best distinguishes organizational culture from organizational climate?

- ☐ **A)** Culture is temporary and climate is permanent
☐ **B)** Culture is relatively enduring, while climate is more temporary and changeable
☐ **C)** Climate can only be measured qualitatively
☐ **D)** Culture is only relevant to nonprofit organizations

B31. Which level of organizational culture is described as the most difficult to study, representing beliefs about reality and human nature that are taken for granted?

- ☐ **A)** Cultural artifacts
☐ **B)** Shared norms
☐ **C)** Cultural values
☐ **D)** Shared assumptions

B32. According to the module, a useful cultural value must be viable, balanced, aligned, and:

- ☐ **A)** Profitable
☐ **B)** Authentic
☐ **C)** Legally mandated
☐ **D)** Anonymous

B33. Which of the following is listed among the forces that help maintain an organization's culture?

- ☐ **A)** The selection and retention of employees
☐ **B)** Random employee turnover with no discipline policy
☐ **C)** A complete absence of rites or ceremonies
☐ **D)** Ignoring how leaders react to problems

B34. According to research cited in the module, when diversity initiatives are combined with a genuine culture of inclusion, organizations tend to see:

- ☐ **A)** Lower performance and higher absenteeism
☐ **B)** Higher performance, lower absenteeism, and higher levels of innovation

- ☐ C) No measurable difference at all
- ☐ D) Increased conflict only

1.7 Ethics

B35. The definition of morality that focuses on whether the process or means used to reach a decision is fair, regardless of the outcome, is called:

- ☐ A) Teleology
- ☐ B) Deontology
- ☐ C) Role morality
- ☐ D) Organizational culture

B36. According to “role morality,” an action is considered moral when:

- ☐ A) It always benefits the person performing it personally
- ☐ B) It is consistent with the expectations of the person's assigned role
- ☐ C) It violates company policy but helps a friend
- ☐ D) It is kept completely secret from management

B37. Which of the following is listed in the module as a guideline for ethical HR policies?

- ☐ A) Employment decisions should be based on subjective biases when performance data is unavailable
- ☐ B) Employees should be treated as objects that can be controlled to maximize output
- ☐ C) Disciplinary actions and criticism should only occur for good cause, with a right to due process
- ☐ D) Personal privacy protections do not apply to job-related information

1.8 HR Research and Analytics

B38. The tendency for employees to behave differently simply because they know they are being observed is known as:

- ☐ A) The Hawthorne Effect
- ☐ B) Role morality
- ☐ C) The matrix tax
- ☐ D) Gap analysis

B39. A research instrument that produces consistent, repeatable results each time it is used is described as:

- ☐ A) Valid
- ☐ B) Reliable
- ☐ C) Inferential
- ☐ D) Descriptive

B40. Which chart is described in the module as best used to show how categories make up parts of a whole, with all segments totaling 100 percent?

- ☐ A) Line graph
- ☐ B) Pie chart
- ☐ C) Scatter plot

☐ **D)** Gantt chart

Part III — True/False Exercises (C1–C40)

Mark whether each statement is True or False.

1.1 HR Operations

C1. The HR department is typically the only department in any organization that is ever responsible for safety programs.

☐ True ☐ False

C2. Human resource policies serve to help managers make rapid and consistent decisions.

☐ True ☐ False

C3. Employee handbooks and policy manuals are the same document and always contain identical content.

☐ True ☐ False

C4. Compensation decisions are always made exclusively by the HR department and never by line managers.

☐ True ☐ False

C5. The control role of HR is sometimes referred to as "functional authority."

☐ True ☐ False

C6. HR generalists typically possess a broad comprehension of all HR functions, while HR specialists usually have deep expertise in one functional area.

☐ True ☐ False

C7. A balance sheet reports a company's income, expenses, and profits over a period of time.

☐ True ☐ False

1.2 Organizational Strategy

C8. A mission statement is generally expected to be measurable in the same way that goals and objectives are.

☐ True ☐ False

C9. Strategy formulation is described in the module as a purely systematic, step-by-step process that never changes once it is set.

☐ True ☐ False

C10. Environmental scanning involves anticipating and interpreting changes in the external environment.

☐ True ☐ False

C11. A core competency refers to unique skills or resources that give an organization a competitive edge.

☐ True ☐ False

C12. Both proactive and reactive strategy formulation can be appropriate, depending on how stable the environment is.

☐ True ☐ False

1.3 Effective HR Management

C13. HR metrics are also referred to in the module as “workforce analytics.”

☐ True ☐ False

C14. Human Capital ROI accounts for compensation cost and benefit cost in its formula.

☐ True ☐ False

C15. According to the module, “world-class HR” organizations were found to have a higher cost of HR per employee than typical HR organizations.

☐ True ☐ False

C16. Cost per Hire measures the entire cost of employee turnover, including lost performance and training costs.

☐ True ☐ False

C17. HR business process outsourcing (HR BPO) arrangements became less popular over time because they proved more costly and difficult to manage than anticipated.

☐ True ☐ False

C18. Outsourcing candidates typically include functions with little potential to create competitive advantage, such as payroll administration and benefits administration.

☐ True ☐ False

C19. The HR-to-Employee Ratio benchmark cited in the module reports an industry average of about 2.6 HR staff per 100 employees.

☐ True ☐ False

1.4 HR Technology and Communication

C20. Artificial intelligence in HR can be used to screen resumes and applications, but the module warns that care must be taken to ensure the process is not discriminatory.

☐ True ☐ False

C21. An organization's enterprise resource planning (ERP) system is unrelated to its HRIS, and the two are never integrated.

☐ True ☐ False

C22. HR portals allow only HR staff, not employees themselves, to view or update personal information.

☐ True ☐ False

C23. A wiki is described in the module as ideal for storing highly sensitive, private employee information.

☐ True ☐ False

C24. Voice mail, text, and email messages can be transmitted simultaneously to many people, which can increase the risk of communication overload.

☐ True ☐ False

1.5 Organizational Design and Development

C25. Product departmentalization typically leads to greater interdepartmental coordination around producing a specific product.

☐ True ☐ False

C26. Decentralization means that power and authority are concentrated at the very top of the organizational hierarchy.

☐ True ☐ False

C27. A tall organizational structure is generally associated with a narrow span of control.

☐ True ☐ False

C28. Highly specialized jobs are described in the module as always more interesting and never boring for employees.

☐ True ☐ False

C29. The “matrix tax” refers to increased role ambiguity, stress, and anxiety experienced by employees who report to more than one manager.

☐ True ☐ False

1.6 Organizational Culture

C30. Culture can typically be changed quickly and easily by a single memo from top management.

☐ True ☐ False

C31. Cultural artifacts include tangible aspects such as dress codes, office furnishings, and ceremonies.

☐ True ☐ False

C32. Diversity programs pursued without a genuine culture of inclusion can sometimes lead to lower morale and higher absenteeism.

☐ True ☐ False

C33. Organizational stories are only meaningful if they are entirely factual; legends and myths have no cultural value.

☐ True ☐ False

C34. Founders tend to have their greatest cultural influence early in an organization's life, though their impact can diminish over time unless institutionalized.

☐ True ☐ False

1.7 Ethics

C35. According to the module, organizational ethics apply only to how the organization treats people outside the company, not to internal employee treatment.

☐ True ☐ False

C36. Role morality is sometimes used to justify actions, such as a defense lawyer representing a client known to be guilty, that would otherwise be considered questionable outside that specific role.

☐ True ☐ False

C37. The module states that an organization should never pursue its objectives by sacrificing the ethical treatment of any person, regardless of how honorable its goal is.

☐ True ☐ False

1.8 HR Research and Analytics

C38. Focus groups typically involve a moderator and eight to twelve people who share a common interest.

☐ True ☐ False

C39. Validity is concerned with the consistency of a measure, while reliability is concerned with whether the instrument measures what it is intended to measure.

☐ True ☐ False

C40. Inferential statistics are used to make inferences about a larger population based on data from a smaller sample.

☐ True ☐ False

Answer Key

Type A written-response exercises have no single correct wording and are not included below; your facilitator will assess these against the concepts covered in the module.

Multiple Choice Answer Key (B1–B40)

B1 C	B2 B	B3 B	B4 B	B5 B
B6 B	B7 C	B8 B	B9 B	B10 C
B11 B	B12 D	B13 A	B14 B	B15 B
B16 B	B17 A	B18 B	B19 C	B20 B
B21 A	B22 A	B23 B	B24 B	B25 B
B26 B	B27 C	B28 B	B29 B	B30 B
B31 D	B32 B	B33 A	B34 B	B35 B
B36 B	B37 C	B38 A	B39 B	B40 B

True/False Answer Key (C1–C40)

C1 F	C2 T	C3 F	C4 F	C5 T
C6 T	C7 F	C8 F	C9 F	C10 T
C11 T	C12 T	C13 T	C14 T	C15 F
C16 F	C17 T	C18 T	C19 T	C20 T
C21 F	C22 F	C23 F	C24 T	C25 T
C26 F	C27 T	C28 F	C29 T	C30 F
C31 T	C32 T	C33 F	C34 T	C35 F
C36 T	C37 T	C38 T	C39 F	C40 T